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Beyond Digital Visibility

Collaborative Media and the Infrastructures of Endurance in Georgian Protest Movements

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Abstract

In the wake of the contested 2024 Georgian parliamentary election and the subsequent suspension of European Union integration, the Georgian public sphere has undergone a radical disruption. As digital platforms are increasingly saturated with state-led *Clouds of Confusion* and strategic repression, this thesis explores how protesters use collaborative media practices to maintain their political existence. Moving beyond the technical focus in Media and Communication Studies (MCS), the research employs a qualitative case study design analyzing the *Black Dot* symbol, the *Voices of Freedom from Prison* newspaper, and the *1km Supra* ritual. Drawing on Chantal Mouffe´s theory of agonistic pluralism and Merlyna Lim's framework of *Human Routers*, the study argues that in times of political turmoil, togetherness is not constructed through consensus but through material and embodied practices that protect a radical democratic identity and build alternative human networks of trust. This study contributes to MCS by reconceptualizing protest communication as a process of endurance rather than moments of mobilization.

It demonstrates how communication functions as an infrastructural and affective form of labor that supports the maintenance of political identity under conditions of conflict and repression. The findings of this study can inform future research in other conflict-affected contexts by highlighting how communication as an infrastructure of endurance sustains political identity and collective presence under repressive conditions.

Keywords: collaborative media, protest communication, infrastructures of endurance, agonistic pluralism, human routers, affective labor, public sphere, Tbilisi, Georgia

01 Introduction

On November 28, 2024, Georgia's political landscape underwent a significant transformation when Prime Minister Irakli Kobakhidze announced the suspension of the country's European Union Accession process. The decision triggered large-scale protests that continued into 2026, marking a critical moment in Georgia's ongoing struggle over democratic governance, national identity, and geopolitical orientation. These protests unfolded within a media environment increasingly characterized by what

Tufekci (2019) conceptualizes as a “Cloud of Confusion,” in which state and non-state actors saturate the public sphere with competing narratives, rendering information difficult to interpret and to act upon politically.

In such contexts, the public sphere is no longer a shared communicative space but becomes fragmented, contested, and shaped by ongoing struggles over meaning, legitimacy, and visibility. This fragmentation is particularly pronounced in hybrid political regimes, where formal democratic structures coexist with informal strategies of repression, disinformation, and surveillance (Mattoni & Treré, 2014; Tufekci, 2019). Under these conditions, digital communication infrastructures, which are often central in studies of contemporary protest movements, may become unstable, risky, or even counterproductive for activists.

This thesis examines how protest communication operates under such conditions of fragmentation and constraint. It argues that when institutional media channels are restricted, and digital visibility entails risks of surveillance and harassment, communication shifts toward what is conceptualized here as *collaborative media practices.* These practices involve the collective production and circulation of meaning through symbolic, material, and relational forms of communication that extend beyond digital platforms.

In this study, *embodied media practices* are defined as forms of communication enacted through physical presence, bodily participation, and co-presence in space, such as demonstrations, rituals, and face-to-face interaction. These practices emphasize the body's role as a communicative medium and are crucial in contexts where digital communication is limited or politically risky. Similarly, *informational disruption* refers to a situation in which dominant flows of information are fragmented, saturated, or strategically manipulated, reducing their clarity and political usability (Tufekci, 2019). Together, these concepts shift the analytical attention from representation and visibility to the material and relational dimensions of communication

To analyze these dynamics, this study moves beyond deliberative models of democracy that prioritize rational consensus. Instead, it draws on Chantal Mouffe's (2007) theory of agonistic pluralism, which conceptualizes democracy as inherently conflictual. From

this perspective, political disagreement is not something to be resolved but transferred into agonistic relations between legitimate adversaries. Building on this framework, the thesis understands protest communication as a practice through which political existence is sustained in and through conflict.

In parallel, the study engages with the media-as-practice perspective, which shifts attention from technological affordances to what people do with their everyday struggles for meaning. With this framework, Merlyna Lim's (2018) concept of the *human router* highlights how individuals act as mediators who filter, translate, and physically circulate information across fragmented communication environments. This is particularly relevant in contexts where digital infrastructures are unstable or saturated with disinformation, requiring alternative forms of communication to sustain collective action

Empirically, the study is based on fieldwork conducted in Tbilisi between 2024 and 2026, combining interviews and on-site observations of protest environments. The analysis focuses on three cases that illustrate different dimensions of protest communication: The *Black Dot* functions as a minimalist, open signifier that enables decentralized participation in the use of symbols. *Voices of Freedom from Prison* demonstrates how communication infrastructures are constructed through human mediation and face-to-face networks, particularly through mothers' roles as human routers. Finally, the *1km Supra* represents an embodied and ritualized form of protest that reclaims public space through collective presence. Together, these cases trace a movement from symbolic expression to infrastructural mediation and embodied collective practice, illustrating how communication is sustained across multiple dimensions under conditions of repression. Importantly, these cases are not treated as isolated instances, but as interconnected fragmentations of a broader communicative ecology. By analyzing them relationally, the study aims to capture how different forms of collaborative media coexist, overlap, and compensate for each other's limitations over time. This perspective allows for a more nuanced understanding of how protest communication operates not as a singular strategy, but as a dynamic system of practices that adapts to changing political and informal conditions.

1.1 Problem Statement

Recent research in Media and Communication Studies (MCS) has demonstrated the central role of digital platforms in contemporary protest mobilization. However, this body of work has been criticized for a persistent digital bias, in which social movements are primarily analyzed through the lens of platform affordances, online visibility, and networked speed (Mattoni & Treré, 2014). While such approaches provide important insights into moments of rapid mobilization, they often fail to account for how protest movements endure under prolonged repression.

In hybrid and authoritarian-leaning contexts, the state power increasingly operates through strategies that fragment the public sphere without necessarily restricting access to information. As Tufekci (2019) argues, information may remain formally available while becoming practically unusable due to overload, contradiction, and emotional exhaustion. Under these conditions, digital visibility can become ephemeral, risky, or even counterproductive, raising critical questions about how political communication, collective identity, and togetherness are sustained when platform-based infrastructures are compromised.

The Georgian protest movement provides a salient empirical context for addressing this problem. As digital environments become saturated with disinformation and harassment, protesters increasingly turn to material, embodied, and participatory media practices. These practices remain under-theorized within mainstream MCS research, which continues to privilege digital mediation and short-term mobilization outcomes over long-term communicative endurance.

This thesis, therefore, addresses the following problem of how political communication and collective identity can be sustained when the public sphere is fragmented, digital infrastructures are fragile, and surveillance is normalized. More specifically, it focuses on the relative lack of analytical attention to non-digital, embodied, and infrastructural forms of communication that enable protest movements to persist over time.

1.2 Research Questions

Against this background, the study addresses the following overall research question:

How do collaborative media practices function as infrastructures of endurance in a protest movement operating under conditions of political repression and a fragmented public sphere?

To answer this question, the thesis is guided by three specific research questions:

1. How are collaborative media practices constructed and enacted by protesters under conditions of political repression and a fragmented public sphere in Georgia?
2. How do symbolic, infrastructural, and embodied media practices contribute to sustaining political existence, collective identity, and togetherness over time?
3. What are the temporal, affective, and structural limits of collaborative media as an infrastructure of endurance under prolonged conditions of state repression and uncertainty?

1.3 Aim and Contribution

The aim of this thesis is to examine how collaborative media practices function as infrastructures of endurance within protest movements. Through a qualitative case study of the Georgian protest movement between 2024 and 2026, the study analyses how protesters sustain communicative capacity, relational ties, and political identity when institutional media channels and digital platforms are constrained.

Drawing on Mouffe's (2007) theory of agonistic pluralism and Lim's (2018) framework of roots, routes, and routers, the thesis conceptualizes protest communication not as a tool for achieving consensus or immediate political outcomes, but as an ongoing practice of sustaining political existence through conflict. By analyzing the cases of the *Black Dot, Voices of Freedom from Prison* newspaper, and the *1km Supra*, the study foregrounds symbolic, infrastructural, and embodied dimensions of communication that are often marginalized in digitally-centric research.

The study contributes to Media and Communication studies in three main ways. First, it challenges the prevailing digital bias by demonstrating how communication persists through material, relational, and embodied practices when digital infrastructures are

fragile. Second, it develops the concept of collaborative media as a form of infrastructural and affective labor required to sustain collective action over time. Third, by situating protest communication within an agonistic democratic framework, the thesis advances a theoretical understanding of togetherness as something produced through conflict rather than consensus (Mouffe, 2007).

Empirically, the study provides original insights into the contemporary protest movement in Georgia, a context that remains underrepresented in international research on media and social movements. More broadly, the findings offer analytical tools for understanding how protest movements navigate fragmentation, surveillance, and political uncertainty while maintaining communicative capacity and collective identity over time.

02 Background

This section provides the historical, political, and cultural context necessary to understand the emergence of the Georgian protest movement between 2024 and 2026. It situates the protests within the country's post-Soviet trajectory, its evolving political economy, and the broader patterns of state-society relations that have shaped cycles of mobilization and repression.

2.1 Political and Historical Context

Since the collapse of the Soviet Union, Georgia has undergone a complex and contested transition towards independence, state-building, and the adoption of Western-oriented democratic norms. A key turning point in this trajectory was the 2003 Rose Revolution, which brought Mikheil Saakashvili and the United National Movement (UNM) to power (Kupatadze, 2023). This period was initially framed nationally and internationally as a moment of democratic transformation.

Saakashvili's governance was characterized by extensive institutional reforms and a strong emphasis on market liberalization. These reforms have been described as an accelerated neoliberal transformation that prioritizes competition, deregulation, and individual responsibility (Kartvelishvili & Khasaia, 2025). At the same time, concerns

were raised regarding the expansion of executive power and the use of state institutions to control political opposition (Kupatadze, 2023).

In 2012, political power shifted to the Georgian Dream (GD) coalition, led by Bidzina Ivanshvili. This transition marked a reconfiguration of the political and economic landscape. Scholars have described this period as a shift toward a form of corporate-style governance, where political authority is closely intertwined with economic power and large-scale private interests (Kartvelishvili & Khasaia, 2025). Under the GD rule, governance practices have been associated with hierarchical decision-making structures and the increasing use of traditional and anti-liberal rhetoric in the political public sphere (Kartvelishvili & Khasaia, 2025).

2.2 Political Repression and the 2024 Protest Wave

The protest movement that emerged in 2024 is situated within a longer history of state responses to public dissent in Georgia. Large-scale demonstrations in 2007, 2011, and 2019 were met with varying degrees of state force, raising concerns about the limits of democratic governance and the treatment of protest activity (Kupatadze, 2023; Pachulia, 2025). These events contribute to an established pattern in which protest cycles are closely linked to state strategies of control and containment.

In addition to physical forms of repression, recent developments indicate a growing reliance on digital strategies for information. Tufekci (2019) describes how contemporary political environments can be characterized by the saturation of information flows, where competing narratives and constant content production make it difficult for individuals to distinguish reliable information from misleading messages.

The immediate trigger for the 2024 protest was the parliamentary election and the Georgian government's subsequent decision to suspend progress toward European Union membership. This shift has been described as a critical moment, with implications for both domestic governance and the country's geopolitical orientation. Public responses to the decision reflected broader concerns regarding democratic accountability and Georgia's long-standing aspiration to align with European institutions (Carnighan, 2016).

2.3 Cultural Context and Protest Practices

Cultural identity and historical memory play a significant role in shaping political mobilization in Georgia. Research has shown that national symbols and narratives are frequently mobilized to connect contemporary political struggles with longer historical trajectories of resistance and statehood (Carnighan, 2016). For example, the revival of historical symbols, such as the red-and-white flag, reflects broader efforts to frame political participation in relation to national identity and collective memory.

In addition to symbolic forms, cultural practices also contribute to the ways in which collective action is organized and experienced. The Georgian *Supra,* a traditional feast associated with hospitality, social bonding, and ritualized communication, represents an established cultural form with deep social significance (Avakoca, 2025). While historically associated with private and communal settings, such practices have also appeared in public contexts during periods of political mobilization.

Scholars have noted that participatory and socially embedded practices can play an important role in shaping how individuals engage with political issues, particularly in contexts where formal institutional channels are perceived as limited (Bishop, 2012). These practices emphasize co-presence, interaction, and shared experiences as important dimensions of collective action.

2.4 Empirical Context: Key Protest Initiatives

To examine how communication operates within the Georgian protest movement between 2024 and 2026, this study focuses on three empirical cases. These cases were selected because they represent different forms of communicative practice, including symbolic expression, infrastructural organization, and embodied participation. Together, they provide a basis for understanding how protest communication is produced across multiple contexts.

The Black Dot

The Black Dot emerged during the announcement of the contested election results in November 2024. During this event, opposition representative Davit Kritadze threw

black liquid at the Central Election Commission chief, Giorgi Kalandarishvili, describing the result as a representation of perceived electoral irregularities (Nechaev, 2024).

Following this incident, the Black Dot appeared as a simple circular symbol reproduced across a variety of surfaces, including walls, posters, stickers, and digital platforms. Its visual simplicity enables widespread replication, contributing to its visibility across contexts. The symbol has been described as an "objectified image", capable of condensing multiple grievances into a single visual form (Awad & Wagoner, 2020, p. 98). Its interpretive openness enables individuals to associate it with a range of political concerns (Nechaev, 2024).

Voices of Freedom from Prison

The initiative *Voices of Freedom from Prison* was developed in response to the detention of individuals involved in the protest movement. The project originated from communication efforts by prisoners and their families, including letters written from detention facilities (Nikuradze, 2025; Gabritchidze, 2025).

These materials were compiled and distributed through printed newspapers, and over 50,000 copies circulated across urban and rural areas in Georgia. Distribution was carried out by mothers and activists, often involving direct interaction and conversation with recipients (Nikuradze, 2025). The initiative exemplifies how communication channels can be organized outside traditional media structures.

The process of collecting, printing, and distributing involved coordinated efforts among participants. Previous research has highlighted how such processes can involve modifications to existing communication infrastructures and the creation of alternative systems for information circulation (Sandvik, 2016). The initiative also reflects the importance of face-to-face interaction in contexts where trust and credibility are central concerns (Lim, 2018).

The 1km Supra

On December 31, 2024, large numbers of protesters gathered in Rustaveli Avenue in central Tbilisi to organize a large-scale public *Supra*, extending from Freedom Square to

the parliamentary building (Avakova, 2025). This event transformed a central urban location into a site of collective gathering and participation.

The *Supra* is recognized as a culturally significant practice, associated with hospitality, ritualized communication, and shared values. During the protest, this traditionally private practice was relocated into a public setting, creating a form of collective participation rooted in established cultural traditions (Avakova, 2025).

Scholarly work on participatory practice suggests that forms of collective engagement can shape how individuals experience and contribute to social and political processes (Bishop, 2012). The event illustrates how familiar cultural formats can be adapted in different contexts to facilitate collective gathering and interaction.

Taken together, these cases reflect the diversity of practices through which protest activity is expressed and organized. They demonstrate how communication can take multiple forms, including symbolic representation, material distribution, and collective participation, within a broader context of political mobilization.

03 Literature Review

3.1 Digital Activism and Networked Protest

A substantial body of research within Media and Communication Studies has examined the role of digital platforms in shaping contemporary protest movements. Early work on digital activism has emphasized how social media enable rapid mobilization, large-scale coordination, and circulation of protest narratives across geographically dispersed networks (Shirky, 2011; Castells, 2015). These perspectives highlight the importance of connectivity, speed, and scalability in explaining the emergence of networked forms of collective action.

Subsequent research has expanded this focus by examining the hybrid nature of contemporary media environments. Mattoni and Treré (2014) argue that protest movements operate in *hybrid media systems,* where older and newer media logics interact. Rather than replacing traditional forms of communication, digital media

become embedded within broader communicative ecologies that include face-to-face interaction, print media, and institutional channels.

At the same time, scholars have pointed out that the emphasis on digital platforms risks producing what has been described as a *digital bias* in the study of social movements (Gerbaudo, 2012; Mattoni & Treré, 2014). This perspective tends to privilege online visibility, viral content, and networked speed, often overlooking how movements sustain themselves beyond moments of rapid mobilization.

3.2 Media and Social Movements

Research within the field of social movements has increasingly examined how media practices are embedded in broader processes of collaborative action. Rather than focusing exclusively on technological affordances, this strand of scholarship explores how communication is shaped by organizational structures, cultural contexts, and political conditions (Downing, 2001; Della Porta & Diani, 2012).

Media have been conceptualized as both resources and arenas for struggle, where movements seek to shape public narratives, gain legitimacy, and mobilize support (Cammaerts, 2012). This includes not only engagement with mainstream media but also development of alternative and grassroots communication infrastructures that allow movements to circulate their own messages (Downing, 2001).

More recent work has highlighted how communication practices are closely tied to processes of identity formation and collective belonging. For example, Gerbaudo (2012) shows how activist communication contributes to the construction of a shared sense of purpose and emotional cohesion, while Milan (2015) emphasizes the role of communication infrastructures in sustaining long-term activism.

These perspectives shift attention from isolated media events to the ongoing practices through which movements maintain visibility, coordination, and collective identity over time.

In addition, these perspectives suggest that media practices cannot be fully understood without considering the broader socio-political environments in which they are embedded. Communication does not occur in a vacuum, but is shaped by power relations, institutional constraints, and cultural expectations. This highlights the importance of contextualizing collaborative media practices within specific political settings, particularly in hybrid regimes where formal democratic structures coexist with informal mechanisms of control. Such an approach strengthened the analytical focus on how communication both reflects and actively shapes political conditions.

3.3 Beyond Visibility: Emerging Critiques

While existing research provides valuable insight into digital activism and media practices, a growing body of scholarship has begun to critically reflect on its limits. One key critique concerns the tendency to prioritize visibility and representation as central dimensions of protest communication.

Tufekci (2019) argues that high levels of visibility do not necessarily translate into political effectiveness, particularly in contexts where information environments are saturated or strategically manipulated. Similarly, Milan (2015) and Mattoni and Treré (2014) point out that focusing on visibility risks overlooking how movements operated under conditions of repression, surveillance, and information overload.

Other scholars have emphasized the importance of material and relational dimensions of communication. For instance, Bishop (2012) highlights the role of participation and co-presence in shaping social and political engagement, while Sandvik (2016) draws attention to the infrastructural work involved in producing and circulating information.

Taken together, these critiques suggest the need to move beyond analyses centered on digital platforms and mediated visibility, and instead examine how communication unfolds through embodied practices, interpersonal relations, and material infrastructures.

This emphasis on embodiment also challenges the conventional distinction between communication and action. Rather than treating communication as the transmission of

messages separate from physical practice, this perspective recognizes that meaning is produced through doing, participating, and being present. In this sense, embodied media practices do not merely represent political positions but actively constitute them, reinforcing the idea that protest communication is inseparable from lived experience and social interaction.

3.4 Identified Research Gap

Across these strands of literature, a common limitation emerges: a tendency to privilege representation, visibility, and digital mediation over material, relational, and embodied dimensions of communication. While exciting research has provided important insight into how protest movements mobilize and gain visibility, less attention has been paid to how communication is sustained over time under conditions of repression, fragmentation, and uncertainty.

In particular, there is a need for empirical and theoretical work that examines how alternative communication practices such as symbolic reproduction, face-to-face interaction, and embodied collective participation contribute to maintaining communicative capacity and collective identity when digital infrastructures are constrained.

This thesis addresses this gap by analyzing collaborative media practices as infrastructures of endurance within the Georgian protest movement between 2024 and 2026.

04 Theoretical Framework

This thesis is guided by Chantal Mouffe's (2007) theory of agonistic pluralism, which serves as the overarching analytical lens for understanding protest communication as a form of political engagement grounded in conflict. From this perspective, consensus is neither fully attainable nor necessarily desirable.

Drawing on this framework, the study approaches protest communication not as a tool for resolving disagreement, but as a practice through which political conflict is

expressed, sustained, and made visible. This perspective informs the analysis of how collective action operates within fragmented and contested public spheres. This overarching perspective also informs how the study understands the production of collective forms of engagement under conditions of uncertainty.

3.1 Agonistic Public Sphere and Political Conflict

Building on the overarching framework of agonistic pluralism, this section further develops how Mouffe´s (2007) theory can be applied to the analysis of protest communication. Mouffe conceptualizes democratic life as inherently conflictual, where competing values, identities, and interests give rise to persistent tensions that cannot be fully resolved. Rather than eliminating these tensions through consensus, democratic processes involve transforming antagonism into agonism, where opposing actors engage as legitimate adversaries.

In this study, this perspective is used to understand protest communication as a practice through which conflict is articulated, negotiated, and sustained within the public sphere. Protest is therefore approached not merely as an expression of dissent, but as a site where political identities and positions are actively produced and contested. The public sphere, in this sense, is not treated as a neutral space for rational deliberation, but as an arena structured by ongoing struggles over meaning, legitimacy, and visibility.

Applied to the Georgian protest movement, this framework enables an analysis of how communicative practices contribute to maintaining the presence of political conflict over time. Rather than interpreting protest as a temporary disruption, this study examines how participants use communication to sustain engagement and resist pressures toward depoliticization or enforced consensus. Drawing on Mouffe (2007), this approach highlights how such practices can be understood as maintaining the conditions for democratic contestation.

3.2 Networked Communication and Human Mediation

To complement the focus on political conflict, this study draws on the media-as-practice perspective, which shifts attention from media technologies to what people do with media in everyday contexts (Couldry, 2004). This approach highlights how

communication emerges through situated practices rather than being determined solely by technological affordances.

Within this framework, Merlyna Lim's (2018) concept of the human router is used to analyze how communication flows are sustained across fragmented environments. Rather than assuming that information circulates automatically through digital networks, this perspective foregrounds the role of individuals as active mediators who select, interpret, and transmit content across different contexts. Human routers, in this sense, connect otherwise fragmented spaces, both physically and socially.

In this study, this perspective enables an analysis of how communication is maintained under conditions where digital infrastructures are unstable, surveilled, or saturated with disinformation. Communication is therefore approached not primarily in terms of visibility, but as a process that unfolds through interpersonal interactions, material distribution, and localized forms of engagement (Mattoni & Treré, 2014; Milan, 2015). This aligns with a broader understanding of communication as operating within hybrid media systems that combine digital and physical dimensions (Mattoni & Treré, 2014).

By foregrounding mediation rather than technology, this framework provides analytical tools for examining how protest movements sustain communication even when dominant infrastructures are constrained or unreliable.

3.3 Embodied and Relational Media Practices

Building on these perspectives, this study conceptualizes protest communication as an embodied and relational practice. This approach moves beyond dominant perspectives in Media and communication studies that prioritize representation and digital visibility, instead foregrounding the material and social dimensions of communication.

In this thesis, embodied practices refer to forms of communication enacted through physical presence, bodily participation, and co-presence in space. These include demonstrations, rituals, and face-to-face interactions, where meaning is produced not only through symbolic representation but also through shared experience and spatial

presence (Bishop, 2012). Embodiment becomes particularly significant in contexts where digital communication is constrained or carries risk or surveillance.

Closely related to this concept is relational communication, which emphasizes that meaning is produced through ongoing social interaction rather than isolated acts of transmission. Communication is therefore understood as a process of building and maintaining relationships, trust, and affective connection over time (Milan, 2015).

The study also engages with the concept of informal disruption (Tufekci, 2019), which describes environments in which information is not necessarily censored but becomes difficult to interpret due to saturation, contradiction, and overload. In such contexts, access to information does not automatically translate into political action, shifting attention toward alternative communicative practices that enable coordination and shared meaning-making.

Taken together, these perspectives inform the study's understanding of collaborative media practices as infrastructures of endurance. Rather than relying on visibility within digital platforms, these practices involve the ongoing production of communication through bodies, relationships, and material processes. This approach provides a basis for analyzing how protest movements sustain communicative capacity and collective engagement over time under conditions of repression and uncertainty.

05 Methodology

5.1 Research Design and Paradigm

This study adopts a qualitative research design grounded in a constructivist paradigm, which assumes that social reality is co-constructed through human interaction and meaning-making (Guba & Lincoln, 1994). This approach is particularly well-suited to analyzing collaborative media practices, as it allows exploration of how participants interpret and enact communication within protest contexts.

Consistent with an exploratory qualitative research design grounded in a constructivist paradigm, the research questions were formulated to guide inquiry into collaborative

media practices without presupposing their outcomes, effectiveness, or political impact (Guba & Lincoln, 1994; Blaikie & Priest, 2017; Mattoni & Treré, 2014).

This approach aligns with media practice perspectives that emphasize situated action, interpretation, and negotiation over causal or outcome-oriented explanations (Couldry, 2004).

I, the researcher, have been based in Tbilisi since September 2024, one month prior to the parliamentary elections. This positioning enables direct observation of the protest movements as they unfolded over time. I have personally witnessed the widespread presence of the *Black Dot* across urban spaces, including on walls, banners, and everyday objects, and I also attended the *1km Supra.*

These experiences informed the study's analytical perspective, grounding theoretical concepts in lived realities. In particular, the adoption of an agonistic framework was shaped by this situated engagement, as it provided a meaningful lens for interpreting the coexistence of conflict, solidarity, and contestation within the protest context.
This positioning, therefore, directly shaped both the analytical focus of the study and the interpretation of empirical material.

5.2 Data Collection

The empirical material consists of three case studies, complemented by three semi-structured interviews with participants involved in the protests in Tbilisi. The cases were selected based on their relevance to collaborative media practices and their prominence within the protest movement. While the number of interviews is limited, the study prioritizes depth, contextual richness, and theoretical integration over breadth, in line with qualitative research principles (Guba & Lincoln, 1994; Carnaghan, 2016).

The empirical material covers the period from the 2024 parliamentary elections to early 2026, a timeframe marked by continuous protest activity in Tbilisi. This period was selected for its significance in shaping contemporary protest dynamics and communication practices in Georgia. The three case studies were chosen based on their relevance within this timeframe and their prominence in the protest movement. By

focusing on this period, the study captures how collaborative media practices evolve over time, rather than analyzing isolated events.

A total of three semi-structured interviews were conducted. One of these was a group interview with two participants, resulting in four individual perspectives included in the empirical material. The semi-structured interviews were conducted to capture participants' perspectives, experiences, and interpretations of their involvement in protest-related media practices. While limited in number, the interviews were designed to provide in-depth insight into how individuals understand and enact their roles within collaborative media processes. The semi-structured format allows for flexibility while maintaining a consistent thematic focus, enabling the exploration of complex and situated practices. In line with qualitative research traditions, the aim is not statistical generalization but analytical depth and contextual understanding (Guba & Lincoln, 1994).

Participants were selected through purposive sampling, focusing on individuals actively engaged in protest-related activities. Ethical considerations, including informed consent and anonymity, were carefully addressed through the research process.

5.2.1 Validation of Information Selection

To ensure a multidimensional understanding of collaborative media practices, Participants were selected through purposive sampling, resulting in four individuals contributing to the empirical material. These perspectives were collected through three interviews, including one group interview. The selection criteria emphasized diversity in generational perspective, professional expertise, and forms of participants' activist labor represented across the three case studies.

- Case 1: Young Protesters' Perspectives: Two informants were selected to represent the younger generation of protesters. Unlike participants in the other two cases, these individuals entered the movement in 2023 and during the 2024 cycle, providing a perspective on the rapid mobilization and digital-native responses to repression. Their active involvement, such as distributing hot tea and coffee to fellow protesters, as well as actively engaging with the *Black Dot*

symbol by painting it on their faces, wearing it on their backpacks and clothes, exemplifies the grassroots collaborative labor and mutual aid that sustain the movement's physical presence.

- Case 2: Media and Longitudinal Expertise. The informant for Case 2 is a Media Producer who served an opposition television program. The participant was chosen due to their extensive experience in Georgian social movements, despite their relatively young age, with involvement dating back to university reforms. Their professional role involved close collaboration with mothers from the *Voices of Freedom from Prison* network, providing unique insight into the intermodal transition from prison letters to national media narratives, as well as the challenges of countering state propaganda. The television program also established a fund that helped finance the creation of *Voices of Freedom from Prison* and supported other protest-related actions. In addition, the initiative helped provide legal assistance to protesters who had been arrested or fined. Over the past year, the Georgian government has frozen the accounts associated with this fund.

- Case 3: Cultural and Artistic Analysis: The informant for Case 3 is a cultural worker, researcher, and artist who uses food as a medium in their practice. Having participated in Georgian street protests for over a decade, this individual was selected for their specialized expertise in the semiotics of food and tradition. Their dual role as participants and artists enabled a deeper analysis of the *1km Supra* as a social sculpture and of its effectiveness in reclaiming urban territory through cultural reconfiguration.

5.2.2 Participant Anonymization and Interview References

To ensure anonymity while maintaining analytical clarity, participants are referred to using role-based pseudonyms that reflect their position within the protest movement.

The following aliases are used throughout the study:

- Young protester 1 (Participant engaged in grassroots protest activities and engagement with the Black Dot)
- Young protester 2 (Participant engaged in grassroots protest activities and engagement with the Black Dot)
- Media producer (Participant involved in protest-related media production)
- Cultural Actor (Participant engaged in artistic and cultural protest practices)
-

These role-based identifiers are used consistently throughout the analysis to distinguish between perspectives while preserving confidentiality. This approach also allows for tracing patterns of similarity and divergence across different roles within the protest movement, supporting the study's focus on interpretive variance.

5.3 Analytical Methods

To provide a comprehensive understanding of collaborative media practices in Georgia, this study employs a multi-methodological qualitative approach grounded in a constructive paradigm. In line with this perspective, social reality is viewed as co-constructed through human interaction and meaning-making, rather than as a single, objective truth. These methods are designed to explore not only what protesters do, but the underlying *why* and *how* of their communicative labor within a repressive environment.

This methodological approach also allows for the integration of different types of empirical material, including interviews, observations, and visual symbolic artifacts. By combining these sources, the analysis captures both the experiential and representational dimensions of protest communication. This strengthens the study's ability to account for the complexity of collaborative practices, which operate simultaneously at symbolic, material, and relational levels.

5.3.1 Agonistic Analysis: Identifying the Political Frontier

As the overarching theoretical lens, Chantal Mouffe's (2007) theory of agonism is operationalized as an analytical method. The study treats empirical data, interviews, and material artifacts as evidence of a symbolic struggle to define the *political frontier*.

This method focuses on identifying how protesters construct a collective “we” in opposition to a hegemonic “them”. The analysis moves beyond consensus-based models to exemplify how collaborative media facilitates a *chain of equivalence*, linking disparate grievances into common projects of resistance without erasing individual differences. By applying an agonistic lens, the research evaluates how the *1km Supra* and the *Black Dot* function as interventions that manifest conflict, allowing participants to *exist in conflict* as adversaries rather than enemies.

5.3.2 Thematic Analysis: Interpretive Variance and Affect

Finally, thematic analysis is applied to the three semi-structured interviews to identify recurring patterns of experience. This method is crucial for capturing *interpretive variance*, the contradictory meanings of participants attributed to the same practice (Guba & Lincoln, 1994).

The analysis focuses on themes of affective labor, specifically how factors like fatigue, fear of surveillance, and *symbolic fatigue* shape the movement's endurance over time. By comparing the narratives of different generations (e.g., younger vs. older activists), the study highlights the emotional and temporal limits of collaborative media as a context for *sneaky occupation* and systemic dysfunction. This thematic approach directly addresses the comparison between the efficiency of digital routers and the trust-building capacity of human routers.

5.4 Analytical Framework

To operationalize the study's theoretical goals, the analysis is guided by an integrated framework that combines Merlyna Lim's (2018) *Roots, Routes, and Routers* model with Chantal Mouffe's (2007) theory of agonistic pluralism. This multi-layered approach enables a granular investigation into how collaborative media practices function as *infrastructures of endurance* within the Georgian protest movement.

5.4.1 Routers: Human Agency vs Digital Fragility

The dimension of Routers identifies the connectors that enable communication between people and places. The analysis employs a comparative lens:

- Digital Routers: Characterized by speed but also by organizational fragility and vulnerability to state-led *Clouds of Confusion* and surveillance.
- The Human Routers (The Dissenting Body): Analyzing the body as a networking device that carries *data packets* of resistance. Unlike digital technical nodes, the human router (e.g., the mothers) provides effective labor and trust-building through face-to-face interaction, which is essential for maintaining communicative capacity when institutional channels are compromised.

06 Ethics & Limitations

6.1 Ethical Framework: Intrinsic Constructivist Ethics

In accordance with the Social constructivist paradigm, ethical considerations are viewed as intrinsic to the research process rather than an external set of rules. Because this inquiry involves transactional and subjectivist interactions between the researcher and the Georgian protesters, the findings are literally created through these relationships. This proximity creates *sticky problems* regarding confidentiality and anonymity, as well as the ethical responsibility to include participants' values within the inquiry. Following the *logic of anticipation* proposed by Blaikie and Priest (2017), this research is specifically designed to contribute *meaningful knowledge* toward the significant social problem of democratic suppression in Georgia (Guba & Lincoln, 1994; Blaikie & Priest, 2017).

6.2 Researcher Positionality and Reflexivity

As a researcher investigating governance and freedom of expression in Tbilisi, it is necessary to engage in reflexivity regarding personal values (Wasserman et. al., 2018). Originating from a Western/Swedish background, a researcher's democratic values can introduce bias into the interpretation of political struggles.

My presence in Tbilisi began in September 2024, coinciding with the start of my master’s program and one month before the pivotal parliamentary elections. This two-year immersion allows this study to be characterized as a prolonged ethnographic

engagement, providing the “Contextual information” necessary to understand the nuances of the Georgian public sphere (Guba & Lincoln, 1994, 00. 106, 114). By personally witnessing the emergence of the *Black Dot* and participating in the *1km Supra*, I have gained vicarious experience that informs the analysis (Guba & Lincoln, 1994, p. 114). Consequently, I acknowledge that my position is not one of total objectivity; rather, the findings are co-constructed through my relationship with the field and its actors (Guba & Lincoln, 1994, pp. 107, 111)

Furthermore, this study acknowledges a narrow scope by focusing primarily on the protesters' perspective and their collaborative media practices, rather than the perspectives of police or state actors.

6.3 Participation Safety: The Economy of Visibility

A central ethical tension in this research is the *economy of visibility* (Lim, 2018). While protesters use collaborative media to gain visibility and power, that visibility also subjects them to the *gaze of spectators* and state surveillance, including AI-based recognition. Ethically, this research must prioritize participants' anonymity to protect them from the material risks of harassment, arrest, and imprisonment that characterize restrictive political environments. In a context where the online world has become hostile due to government-instigated harassment and trolling, the researcher has a duty to ensure that the documentation of *hidden transcripts*, private critiques of power, does not inadvertently expose individuals to state retaliation (Tufekci, Z. 2019).

6.4 Safety of the Researcher

The researcher's safety is equally paramount, particularly when conducting visual and digital ethnography in a repressive landscape. Digital activism in such regions is often met with mass reporting, shadow banning, and state-sponsored cyber attacks. As noted by Tufekci (2019), dissidents and those documenting them are frequently faced with a *cloud of confusion* and digital repression that can lead to information being made unactionable. Consequently, the researcher must adopt secure communication practices to avoid becoming a target of the state's repressive toolkit.

6.5 Limitations: Interpretive Variance and Situated Meaning

A key limitation of this study concerns interpretive variance among participants and the inherently situated nature of meaning-making in protest communication. Within a constructive paradigm, social reality is understood as co-constructed and multiple rather than singular or fixed (Guba & Lincoln, 1994). While the research aims to capture collaborative media practices as collectively produced, the empirical material demonstrates that symbols, rituals, and communicative infrastructures are experienced unevenly across individuals and over time, reflecting differences in positionality, emotional investment, and exposure to repression (Mattoni & Treré, 2014; Couldry, 2004).

Participants attributed different, and at times contradictory, meanings to the same practices, particularly regarding the *Black Dot* symbol, which was described both as a marker of collective presence and as a non-consoling reminder of systemic failure. Such divergence aligns with research on participatory and symbolic media, which shows that the affective force of collaborative artifacts is temporally unstable and context-dependent, shifting as political conditions and levels of repression change (Silvestri, 2018). These interpretive differences limit the extent to which findings can be generalized as representative of a unified protest experience.

However, rather than constituting a methodological weakness, this variance reflects the fragmentary, affective, and unstable conditions under which collaborative media operate in hybrid and repressive communication environments (Lim, 2018; Tufekci, 2019). The study therefore prioritizes analytical depth and contextual understanding over representational exhaustiveness, acknowledging that protest communication is contingent, temporally situated, and shaped by emotions, material, and political pressures (Askanius, 2019; Mattoni & Treré, 2014).

6.6 Ethics of Representation

Finally, there is an ethical imperative regarding how protesters are represented. Following Wasserman et al. (2018), this research seeks to avoid the mainstream media tendency to frame protests as *riot porn*, irrational violence stripped of political context.

Instead, the study validates the language of emotion, outrage, and activism as a legitimate form of democratic communication from *below*, rather than delegitimizing it in the eyes of the elite audience.

07 Presentation and Analysis of Results

7.1 Introduction to the Empirical Analysis: Collaborative Media Under Conditions of Repression

This chapter presents the study's empirical analysis, examining how collaborative media practices emerged, operated, and were experienced within the Georgian protest movement between the 2024 parliamentary elections and early 2026. Guided by the research questions, the analysis focuses on how protesters collectively produced, circulated, and sustained communication amid political repression, informational fragmentation, and prolonged uncertainty.

This section draws on the three interconnected cases, the *Black Dot* symbol, the *Voices of Freedom from Prison* newspaper, and the *1km Supra*, each representing a distinct yet overlapping dimension of collaborative media. While analytically separated for clarity, these cases are understood as part of a broader communicative ecosystem in which symbolic, infrastructural, and embodied practices interact across physical and digital environments. Together, they illustrate how protest communication in Tbilisi extends beyond institutional media and formal political actors, relying instead on shared participation, material practices, and human labor.

Semi-structured interviews with protesters, media workers, and cultural activists constitute a central component of the analysis. Rather than treating interview data as illustrative evidence for predefined theoretical claims, this chapter uses participants' accounts as sites where meanings are negotiated, contested, and sometimes destabilized. In particular, the interviews revealed significant interpretive variance in how participants understood and valued collaborative media practices over time. Divergent experiences, ranging from solidarity and empowerment to exhaustion, ambivalence, and disenchantment, are treated as analytically productive, shedding light on the unstable conditions under which protest communication operates in repressive contexts.

Methodologically, the analysis is grounded in a practice-based understanding of media (Couldry, 2004; Mattoni & Treré, 2014) and Lim's (2018) framework of roots, routes, and routers. This approach allows the chapter to examine the following:

- roots, in the form of cultural traditions, historical memory, and national identity;
- routes, including intermodal circulation across analog and digital channels; and
- routers, particularly the human actor whose body, movements, and emotional labor enable communication to persist despite repression.

The structure of the chapter reflects both empirical differentiation and analytical progression. Each case study is analyzed in its own section, integrating observational material, interview data, and theoretical interpretation. The analysis then moves beyond individual cases to identify cross-cutting patterns related to temporality, affect, sustainability, and the limits of symbolic communication. Rather than assessing the effectiveness of protest communication in terms of political outcomes, the section focuses on how communication was made possible, how visibility was maintained, how narratives traveled, and how participants coped with fear, fatigue, and fragmentation.

Importantly, the empirical analysis is not only descriptive but theoretically driven. The concepts of collaborative media (Couldry, 2004; Löwgren & Reimer, 2013), affective labor (Lim, 2018), and agonistic pluralism (Mouffe, 2007) function as analytical tools that make it possible to interpret the observed practices.

Collaborative media enables the identification of decentralized, collectively produced communication practices across the cases. Lim's (2018) framework of roots, routes, and routers enables the mapping of how communication flows across fragmented environments. Mouffe´s (2007) theory provides the lens through which these practices are understood as political, specifically as processes of constructing and maintaining a collective identity through conflict.

Thus, the following analysis illustrates not only what protesters do, but how these practices can be understood through the theoretical framework outlined in Chapter 4.

7.2 Case 1: The Black Dot: Symbolic Collaboration and Interpretive Ambivalence

The Black Dot emerged from a highly mediated incident during the announcement of the contested 2024 parliamentary election results, when opposition representative Davit Kirtadze splashed black liquid on the chair of the Central Election Commission. Although the act itself was brief, interviewees emphasized that its symbolic afterlife far exceeded the initial event. As one participant explained, the symbol quickly came to represent a shared moment of rupture: It became “a very good representation of why we were standing in the streets” (Young protester 1).

Rather than being introduced through formal political channels, the symbol circulated through informal social networks and everyday protest practices. Participants described encountering the dot repeatedly across urban faces “on our faces, on bags, everywhere” (Young protester 1), often before any fixed meaning had emerged. This indicates a process of collective authorship in which meaning develops through repetition and participation rather than centralized design.

From an analytical perspective, this circulation can be understood through the media-as-practice framework (Couldry, 2004), where media are produced through social action rather than treated as static objects. The Black Dot gains meaning through its continuous reproduction, aligning with a participatory and co-creative understanding of media (Löwgren & Reimer, 2013). At the same time, its spread reflects decentralized communication, where visibility emerges through everyday practices rather than coordinated messaging.

My own observations in Tbilisi further support this process. The symbol appeared across multiple contexts, including graffiti, banners, and moving objects such as a flag carried through the streets. In one instance, a protester riding an electric scooter carried a flag marked with the Black Dot, which moved through and physically interacted with other bodies in urban space. This illustrates how the symbol circulates not only visually but also spatially and affectively, producing moments of shared presence.

Drawing on Mouffe's (2007) theory of agonistic pluralism, the Black Dot can be understood as sustaining political conflict without requiring consensus. Rather than unifying participants around a fixed meaning, it enables a shared political frontier while allowing interpretive differences to persist. Togetherness, in this sense, emerges not through agreement but through recognition and co-presence within a contested public sphere.

Participants also emphasized that the symbol's accessibility was central to its rapid diffusion. Its minimalist form allowed it to be reproduced with minimal resources, contributing to what one interviewee described as its function as “like a flag of the protest” (Young protester 1). Crucially, this “flag” does not represent a singular ideology; instead, it condenses a range of grievances into a shared visual marker.

At the same time, interview data revealed significant interpretive ambivalence. Not all participants experienced the symbol as empowering. One interviewee explicitly rejected the idea that it created comfort or belonging, describing it instead as “just a reminder that the system is fucked up” (Young protester 2). This suggests that the symbol does not stabilize collective identity but instead accommodates divergent emotional and political responses.

Other participants, however, described moments of shared recognition when encountering the symbol in public space. As one interview noted, being part of the protest more broadly generated a sense of collective experience, where “you're not alone.. You're with us, we're going to do this together” (Young protester 1). While this feeling is not tied exclusively to the symbol itself, the Black Dot contributes to these moments by marking visible points of connection across dispersed actors.

These contrasting perspectives highlight how the symbol functions as an open, flexible reference point rather than a unifying emblem. It allows participants to engage with the protest on different terms, accommodating both solidarity and frustration. In this sense, the Black Dot functions less as a representation of unity and more as a medium through which different affective states, including anger, exhaustion, and belonging, can be expressed simultaneously.

Finally, the temporal dimension of the symbol reveals its limitations. While initially carrying strong symbolic force, its impact diminished over time as repression intensified and crises became normalized. As one participant explained, “now horrible things happen every day…you don't even need a Dot to remember what is happening” (Young Protester 2). This points to a process of symbolic fatigue, in which repetition reduces the symbol's capacity to mobilize affect or attention.

This limitation highlights the constraints of symbolic media in sustaining long-term protest engagement. While symbols enable recognition and visibility, they are insufficient on their own to maintain collective action. As Lim (2018) suggests, communication depends on ongoing relational and infrastructural work. Without such supporting practices, symbolic forms risk losing their effectiveness under prolonged conditions of repression.

7.3 Case 2: Voices of Freedom from Prison: Infrastructural Labor and Human Routers

The case of Voices of Freedom from Prison highlights how protest communication is sustained through infrastructural and relational practices amid informal disruption. Within a media environment characterized by what Tufekci (2019) describes as “clouds of confusion,” where information is saturated, distorted, or rendered politically unusable, digital communication alone is insufficient to build trust and mobilize action. In response, protesters engage in forms of infrastructural adaptation in which communication is reconfigured through embodied and interpersonal practices.

Drawing on Lim's (2018) concept of the human router, the mothers and family members involved in this initiative can be understood as mediators who physically carry narratives across fragmented spaces. Rather than relying on digital platforms, they connect prisons, urban centers, and rural regions through direct interaction. AS one participant explained, “the only thing that works...is physical presence, to be there and talk with people face-to-face” (Media Producer). This highlights how trust is increasingly produced through relational proximity rather than mediated visibility.

The newspaper itself emerges through a process of distribution and labor-intensive communication. Beginning with handwritten letters from prisoners, the material is collected, edited, printed, and then physically distributed by networks of families and activists. This process requires what can be understood as infrastructural labor: coordinated, time-intensive work that sustains communication beyond institutional channels. As the interviewee noted, the initiative emerged from frustration with institutional actors who “did not produce tangible outcomes,” leading participants to organize communication independently (Media Producer).
Through this process, communication is not simply transmitted but actively produced through movement, coordination, and repetition. The distribution of over 50,000 copies across geographically dispersed areas illustrates how participants perform work of connectivity typically associated with formal media systems. In this sense, the initiative aligns with Couldry's (2004) understanding of media as practice, while Lims's (2018) framework helps explain how communication travels through hybrid routes that combine physical and informal flows.

At the same time, these communicative practices unfold within highly polarized environments. Interview data shows that recipients do not uniformly accept the message. Some individuals express empathy, particularly when encountering the stories as parents, while others reject the message entirely, viewing prisoners as “radicals” or “vandals” influenced by state narratives (Media Producer). This highlights how communication is negotiated within contested social contexts, rather than simply received.

From an agonistic perspective (Mouffe, 2007), these interactions can be understood as forms of engagement across difference, where communication does not resolve disagreement but sustains the possibility of political contestation. The face-to-face encounter becomes a site where competing interpretations coexist, but where mutual recognition remains possible.

A central dimension of this case is the affective labor performed by participants. Beyond distribution information, the mothers and activists maintain emotional connections with imprisoned individuals and with border networks of supporters. As the interviewee explained, participation is motivated by the need to ensure that the prisoners

“feel that we are still there” (Media Producer). This highlights how communication operates not only at the level of information exchange but as a practice of care, presence, and emotional support.

This relational dimension extends beyond the immediate network of participants. Repeated interaction, travel, and shared effort contribute to the formation of social bonds that exceed prior social divisions. At the same time, these practices are shaped by fear, dependency, and uneven access to information. In rural areas, participants encountered individuals who were reluctant to engage openly due to economic dependence on the state or fear of surveillance. As one participant recounted, people were “afraid to say something…because they are dependent on the government” (Media Producer). This illustrates how communication is constrained by broader structural conditions, including economic precarity and political pressure.

Despite these limitations, participants describe moments in which communication produced shifts in understanding, even if subtle or temporary. Rather than generating immediate political change, the initiative operates through what the interviewee described as “planting a seed,” a gradual process that may influence perceptions over time (Media Producer). This temporal dimension challenges the assumption that communication must produce immediate outcomes to be effective.

At the same time, the case reveals the limits of these practices. Sustained engagement requires significant emotional and physical investment, often leading to exhaustion and withdrawal. The interviewee described how prolonged involvement resulted in “huge frustration” and an inability to continue participating at the same level (Media Producer). This highlights how maintenance of communication infrastructures depends on continuous labor that is difficult to sustain over time.

Taken together, this case demonstrates how collaborative media function as an infrastructure system rather than a symbolic or event-based form of communication. Through the embodied work of human routers, communication is sustained across fragmented environments, enabling the continued circulation of narratives, the maintenance of relational ties, and the persistence of political engagement.

In this context, togetherness emerges not as a stable condition but as an ongoing achievement, produced through sustained relational labor amid uncertainty, repression, and informal fragmentation.

7.4 Case 3: The 1km Supra: Embodied Protest and the Reconfiguration of Public Space

The 1km Supra represents a distinct form of protest communication, in which political expression is enacted through embodied cultural practice rather than through symbolic representation or informal transmission. Based on direct observation, the event took place on New Year's Eve along Rustaveli Avenue, where participants formed a continuous table extending through the city's central political space. This transformation of the street produced an atmosphere that appeared, at once, both ordinary and extraordinary: a familiar cultural ritual unfolding within a highly contested political context.

Participants described how attending the Supra felt like a refusal to retreat into the private sphere. As one interviewee explained, being present was a way of demonstrating that “we're still going to celebrate, but we will still remember what is happening… we're not leaving this space” (Cultural Actor). This highlights how the event functioned as both a continuation of protest and a reconfiguration of everyday life, blurring the boundaries between celebration and political action.

From an analytical perspective, this transformation can be understood through the media-as-practice framework (Couldry, 2004), where communication is produced through what people do together rather than transmitted as content. The Supra did not communicate through slogans or messages, but through participation itself. Meaning emerged through shared presence, co-presence in space, and the coordinated enactment of a cultural ritual in a politicized setting.

At the same time, the Supra can be interpreted as a response to attempts to delegitimize the protest movement. Interview data indicate that state narratives frequently framed protesters as anti-national, radical, or disconnected from Georgian traditions. In this context, the use of the Supra- a deeply rooted cultural practice functioned as a

counter-hegemonic intervention. As one participant noted, the event expressed a collective message that “this is Georgia…and this is our space” (Cultural Actor). By mobilizing recognizable cultural symbols such as shared food, traditional music, and collective rituals, participant reasserted their claim to national identity.

This re-articulation of cultural symbols can be understood through Mouffe's (2007) concept of floating signifiers. The meaning of “Georgian culture” is not fixed but contested, and the supra becomes a site where competing interpretations are negotiated. Rather than rejecting tradition, protesters reclaim it, positioning themselves as legitimate representatives of the nation in opposition to the ruling hegemony.

The organization of the Supra further demonstrates the collective and infrastructural dimensions of protest. Although participation appeared spontaneous, interview data suggest that the event required coordinated planning, including funding, logistics, and the arrangement of uniform tables across a one-kilometer stretch. Participation, therefore, extended beyond attendance to include preparation, contribution, and collective production. In this sense, the event aligns with the idea of collaborative media, where communication is enacted through shared action.

Importantly, the Supra also transformed Rustaveli Avenue into what can be understood, through Mouffe (2007), as an agonistic space. Where the physical presence of the table reconfigured the street from a site of confrontation into a space where participants could “exist in conflict” without withdrawing. As one interviewee described, the act of occupying the space was not only about protest but about refusing disappearance: maintaining presence in a space where absence was expected.

At the same time, the event produced a visible sense of togetherness that extended beyond immediate social networks. Participants described the Supra enabled interaction with strangers, creating opportunities for conversation, exchange, and collective experience. Practices such as sharing food, distributing drinks, and engaging in spontaneous dialogue reinforced relational connections across otherwise fragmented groups. However, this togetherness should not be understood as uniform, universally experienced.

Interview data reveal a degree of ambivalence toward the event. While some participants described it as powerful and memorable, “something hopeful…something you will never see again” (Cultural Actor), others experienced it with a sense of distance or even discomfort, describing elements of it as “slightly cringe” or lacking a long-term strategic significance. This highlights that the Supra does not only produces a singular meaning but also accommodates differing interpretations and emotional responses.

This ambivalence reflects broader limitations of affective and symbolic protest forms. While the event generated visibility and emotional resonance, it did not necessarily translate into sustained political momentum. Instead, its impact can be understood in terms of affective resilience: providing temporary relief, re-energizing participants, and maintaining engagement during periods of declining intensity.

In this sense, the Supra illustrates both the potential and the limits of embodied protest communication. It demonstrated how collaborative media can operate through cultural practice, spatial occupation, and relational interaction, enabling participants to maintain presence and connection within a repressive environment. At the same time, it highlights that such practices are situational, fragile, and dependent on continued participation.

Taken together, this case shows that protest communication does not rely solely on message transmission or institutional visibility. Instead, it can be enacted through the reconfiguration of everyday practices, where culture, space, and participation combine to produce moments of collective engagement. In such contexts, togetherness emerges not as a stable condition, but as a temporary and contested achievement, sustained through shared presence within an ongoing field of political conflict.

7.5 Cross-Case Analysis

Building on the empirical analysis, this section conceptualizes collaborative media as a multidimensional model of practice. Across the three cases, togetherness emerges not as a fixed condition, but as a relational process enacted differently through symbolic, infrastructural, and embodied forms of collaborative media.

Furthermore, the interplay between these dimensions highlights that collaborative media should not be understood as a fixed category, but as a processual and context-dependent phenomenon. Its form and function shift in relation to changing political pressures, technological conditions, and levels of repression. This reinforces the need to analyze collaborative media as an adaptive system, rather than a stable set of practices.

7.5.1 Collaborative Media as a Multidimensional and Temporal System

Building on empirical analysis, collaborative media can be theoretically understood as a multidimensional system of practice structured through the framework of roots, routes, and routers (Lim, 2018), combined with the concept of agonistic pluralism (Mouffe, 2007).

Across the three cases, collaborative media operate through symbolic, infrastructural, and embodied dimensions, which correspond to different configurations of practice, communication flows, and human mediation. These dimensions are analytically distinct but interconnected, forming what this study conceptualizes as infrastructures of endurance.

The *Black Dot* operates primarily through symbolic compression, enabling rapid recognition and low-threshold participation. The *Voices of Freedom from Prison* newspaper functions infrastructurally, sustaining communication through human-mediated distribution, coordination, and relational labor. The *1km Supra* mobilizes embodied ritual, transforming cultural practice into a spatial and affective mode of communication rooted in co-presence.

Interview data indicate that these dimensions are not interchangeable but mutually reinforcing. While symbolic forms facilitate visibility and recognition, infrastructural practices sustain communication over time, and embodied practices produce moments of collective presence and affective renewal. Together, they form what this study conceptualizes as infrastructures of endurance: a relational system of communicative practices that enables political identity, connection, and visibility to persist despite sustained repression.

This multidimensional model directly addresses RQ1 by demonstrating how collaborative media is constructed through diverse but interconnected practices, rather than through a single communicative form.

A key pattern across the cases concerns the temporal dynamics of collaborative media practices. Symbolic forms such as the *Black Dot* emerge rapidly and circulate widely, but their impact tends to diminish over time as repression becomes normalized and new events displace earlier meanings. This process of symbol fatigue highlights the limited durability of purely representational forms.

In contrast, infrastructural practices, such as the distribution of the prison newspaper, demonstrate greater temporal continuity. However, this endurance comes at a higher cost, requiring sustained labor, coordination, and emotional investment. Participants must continually reproduce the communicative infrastructure through physical efforts and relational engagement.

Embodied practices, exemplified by the *1km Supra*, occupy an intermediate position. They function as episodic interventions that generate affective intensity and temporary renewal, particularly during latency phases. However, their impact is situational and cannot be sustained continuously without transformation or repetition.

Taken together, these findings indicate that no single form of collaborative media is sufficient to sustain protest communication over time. Instead, endurance depends on the interplay between these temporal modalities, where visibility, labor, and affect are distributed across different forms of practice. This directly informs RQ3 by demonstrating the temporal limits and dependencies of collaborative media under prolonged conditions of repression.

7.5.2 Affect, Participation, and Togetherness

Across all three cases, affective dynamics emerge as a central organizing force shaping both participation and sustainability. Interview data consistently highlight experiences of hope, recognition, fear, exhaustion, and ambivalence, indicating that collaborative media operates not only as a communicative system but as an affective infrastructure.

Symbolic forms initially generate feelings of recognition and alignment, but these can give way to fatigue as political conditions deteriorate. Infrastructural practices require sustained emotional engagement, including care, solidarity, and commitment, which can place significant strain on participants over time. Embodied practices create moments of collective uplift and temporary relief, but may also be experienced as insufficient or strategically limited.

This affective dimension reveals that participation in collaborative media is conditioned not only by access or opportunity, but by emotional capacity. Fear of surveillance, repeated exposure to repression, and the normalization of crisis all shape how individuals engage with communicative practices.

At the same time, affect also functions as a sustaining force. Practices such as face-to-face interaction, shared rituals, and symbolic recognition enable participants to maintain a sense of connection and purpose despite adverse conditions. In this sense, collaborative media facilitates togetherness not as a stable emotional state, but as a fluctuating process shaped by both resilience and exhaustion.

Across the three cases, togetherness emerges not as consensus or shared agreement, but as a relational and processual condition produced through ongoing communicative practices. Each case illustrates a different modality through which togetherness is enacted.

In the case of the *Black Dot*, togetherness is achieved through shared visibility and symbolic recognition. For instance, participants described encountering the symbol repeatedly across bodies, flags, and urban spaces, such as when protesters painted the dot on their faces or carried it on banners and personal belongings through the city (Young Protester 1). These repeated encounters enabled recognition among strangers who did not necessarily share the same interpretation, creating a sense of co-presence within a divided public sphere.

In the case of the *Voices of Freedom from Prison* newspaper, togetherness is sustained through relational and affective labor. This is exemplified by the work of the mothers

who traveled across more than 25 towns, distributing newspapers and engaging in direct conversation with citizens in marketplaces and public spaces (Media Producer). Through these face-to-face encounters, trust was built over time, allowing participants to remain connected across geographical distance and political division, even when digital communication was distrusted or inaccessible.

In the case of the *1km Supra*, togetherness is expressed through embodied co-presence. For example, thousands of participants gather around a continuous table on Rustaveli Avenue, sharing food, engaging in conversation, and collectively occupying the space on New Year's Eve. As described by a participant, the event created a space where strangers could “speak their mind” and recognize one another as part of a shared political moment (Cultural Actor). In this setting, togetherness was enacted through being physically present in a contested public space, despite ongoing political conflict.

Taken together, these findings support Mouffe's (2007) concept of agonistic pluralism. The findings suggest that togetherness is not based on eliminating differences or achieving consensus, but on the ability to maintain connection and mutual recognition within a context of conflict. Collaborative media practices function as the mechanism through which this agonistic togetherness is made possible and sustained.

This directly addresses RQ2 by demonstrating how different forms of collaborative media help maintain political existence, collective identity, and relational connection over time. These findings further support Mouffe's (2007) theory by showing that collective identity does not require consensus but is sustained through ongoing negotiation within a shared political space.

Thus, the theoretical framework not only explains the empirical findings but makes them analytically visible as processes of political identity formation.

7.5.3 Fragility and the Limits of Collaborative Media

While collaborative media practices enable endurance, the analysis also highlights their fragility. Across all cases, participants are uneven, meaning is unstable, and sustainability is contingent on continued effort and favorable conditions. No single

practice guarantees continuity, and all are vulnerable to disruption, fatigue, and external pressures.

Despite these limitations, participants consistently frame these practices as necessary. In the absence of reliable institutional channels and amid fractured public communication, collaborative media provides one of the few available means of maintaining presence, visibility, and connection.

Rather than functioning as tools for immediate political transformation, collaborative media practices operate as mechanisms of persistence. They allow participants to navigate conditions of repression, maintain a shared political identity, and sustain communicative capacity over time.

In this sense, collaborative media emerges not as a stable solution, but as a dynamic and adaptive system of practices oriented toward endurance. It is through this ongoing labor of maintenance, participation, and rearticulation that protest movements remain communicatively and politically alive within a disrupted public sphere.

This distinction also raises an important theoretical question regarding the relationship between collaborative media and institutional media. In this study, collaborative media can be understood as a broader category of communication practices that are distinct from institutional media in both structure and function.

Institutional media is typically characterized by centralized production, regulated distribution, and formalized gatekeeping processes (Tufekci, 2019, p. 367). While such systems can provide reach and legitimacy, they are also vulnerable to political control, censorship, and strategic manipulation, particularly in hybrid and repressive regimes. In contrast, collaborative media is decentralized, collectively produced, and sustained through participation rather than institutional authority (Couldry, 2004, p. 117; Löwgren & Reimer, 2013, p. 155).

This distinction is significant because it explains why collaborative media becomes essential under conditions of repression. When institutional media channels are compromised or disrupted, communication must rely on more flexible, relational, and

resilient forms. Collaborative media practices, as demonstrated across the cases, are not dependent on fixed infrastructures but are continuously reproduced through human action.

These findings suggest that for media to function as a mechanism of persistence, rather than momentary mobilization, it must possess specific qualities. First, it must be accessible, allowing low-threshold participation, as seen in the simplicity of the *Black Dot*. Second, it must be relational, enabling trust-building and sustained interaction, as demonstrated in the face-to-face distribution of the prison newspaper. Third, it must be adaptable, capable of moving across hybrid analog-digital networks through intermodality (Lim, 2018). Finally, it must be embodied, rooted in physical presence and social practice, as illustrated in the *1km Supra.*

These qualities enable collaborative media to operate not as static channels, but as dynamic and resilient systems of communication that can persist despite fragmentation, surveillance, and repression. In this sense, collaborative media is not only an alternative to institutional media but a necessary form of communicative infrastructure for sustaining political identity and collaborative presence over time.

While the applied theoretical framework provided strong tools for interpreting collaborative media practices, the findings also highlight certain limitations. In particular, Mouffe's framework emphasizes the persistence of political identity through conflict, yet empirical material demonstrates that affective fatigue and fragmentation can destabilize this process over time. Similarly, Lim's concept of human routers helps explain the durability of communication infrastructures, but may understate the emotional and logistical burdens placed on participants who sustain these networks.

7.6 Summary of Key Empirical Findings

This section has examined how collaborative media practices operated within the Georgia protest movement through three interconnected empirical cases: a minimalist protest symbol, a hand-circulated prison newspaper, and a large-scale embodied ritual. Across these cases, collaborative media emerged not as a unified or stable form, but as a

heterogeneous set of practices shaped by repression, affective labor, and temporal change.

The analysis demonstrated that symbolic collaborative media, exemplified by the *Black Dot*, enabled rapid recognition and low-threshold participation during moments of heightened mobilization. However, interview data revealed significant interpretive variance, with participants attributing different, sometimes contradictory, meanings to the same symbol. While some experienced the *Black Dot* as a marker of shared presence, others understood it as a non-reassuring reminder of systemic dysfunction rather than a source of comfort or unity. This ambivalence highlights both the potential and the limits of symbolic compression in sustaining protest communication over time.

In contrast, the *Voices of Freedom from Prison* newspaper illustrated collaborative media as a form of human-mediated infrastructure in which both the medium and the practice of circulation are central. While interpersonal interaction played a crucial role, the printed newspaper itself enabled the stabilization, reproduction, and circulation of otherwise fragile prison narratives. Unlike digital communication, which is easily manipulated or dismissed within a cloud of confusion, the materiality of the newspaper allowed information to travel physically across spaces, to be held, shared, and revisited in face-to-face encounters. In this sense, collaborative media is not reducible to social interaction alone; rather, the medium serves as a carrier of meaning, extending communication beyond individual encounters. At the same time, this infrastructural model demanded continuous labor and exposed participants to exhaustion, surveillance, and risk.

The *1km Supra* demonstrated how embodied ritual can function as collaborative media by transforming culturally embedded practices into communicative interventions. While Löwgren and Reimer (2013) primarily conceptualize collaborative media as co-produced digital and interactive systems, this case extends their framework by illustrating how collaborative production can also take place through embodied, spatial practices. The supra did not rely on a fixed technological medium, but operated as a collectively produced communication environment in which participation itself constituted the medium. By reconfiguring a private tradition into a public act, protesters temporarily reclaimed contested urban space and countered state narratives that framed

dissent as anti-Georgian. However, as interviewees noted, the impact of such rituals was primarily affective and episodic, offering moments of renewal rather than sustained political continuity.

Across all three cases, several cross-cutting patterns emerged. First, collaborative media practices operated across symbolic, infrastructural, and embodied dimensions, often intersecting but differing in durability and cost. Second, temporality played a decisive role: While symbols circulated quickly, infrastructural practices endured longer, but required continuous labor, and embodied practices provided episodic moments of affective renewal rather than long-term continuity. Third, affect, in the form of hope, fear, fatigue, and solidarity, functioned as a central organizing force, shaping participation and constraining sustainability under prolonged repression.

Taken together, these findings demonstrate that collaborative media does not simply describe participation but identifies specific communicative forms that enable persistence through the combination of materiality, reproducibility, relational interaction, and embodied presence.

Through this interplay of practices, protest communication can endure beyond moments of visibility and remain operational within a disrupted and contested public sphere. This highlights the importance of understanding collaborative media not as isolated phenomena, but as dynamic systems through which political existence is sustained over time.

08 Conclusion

8.1 Summary of Findings

This thesis demonstrates that collaborative media practices function not merely as tools of protest but as infrastructures that maintain political identity and communicative capacity under conditions of repression. Through the analysis of the *Black Dot, the Voices of Freedom from Prison* newspaper, and the *1km Supra*, the research has identified three distinct dimensions of communicative resistance: symbolic compression, infrastructural labor, and embodied ritual.

The findings indicate that symbols like the *Black Dot* serve as minimalist triggers that articulate national critique but are subject to symbolic fatigue as repression becomes normalized (Young Protester 2). In contrast, the labor of family members acting as Human Routers demonstrates how connectivity is maintained through affective labor and intermodality when digital channels are saturated by a state-sponsored *Cloud of Confusion* (Lim, 2018; Tufekci, 2019; Media Producer). Finally, the *1km Supra* illustrates how reconfiguring private traditions into public acts can reclaim contested space, thereby creating an agonistic public sphere in which dissent is physically manifested (Mouffe, 2007; Cultural Actor).

8.2 Answering the Research Questions

The findings of this study can be understood through the applied theoretical framework. Collaborative media practices are constructed through decentralized, participatory processes, which align with Couldry's (2004) media-as-practice approach. The cases demonstrate that communication is collectively produced rather than transmitted through institutional channels.

The findings further show that collaborative media sustain political existence and togetherness through symbolic, infrastructural, and embodied practices. Through Lim's (2018) framework, these practices can be understood as different configurations of roots, routes, and routers that enable communication to persist across disrupted environments. From Mouffe's (2007) perspective, these processes serve as mechanisms for maintaining political identity through agonistic engagement rather than consensus, thereby addressing RQ2.

At the same time, the analysis identifies clear limitations of collaborative media. Symbolic forms are subject to fatigue, infrastructural practice requires continuous labor, and embodied practice is temporally bounded. These limitations can be interpreted through the concept of affective labor (Lim, 2018), which highlights the emotional costs of sustained participation, thereby addressing RQ3

Taken together, these findings demonstrate how collaborative media is constructed, how it sustains political existence, and what limitations shape its long-term viability under conditions of repression.

8.3 Theoretical and Empirical Contribution

This study contributes to Media and Communication Studies (MCS) by integrating multiple frameworks to explain how protest communication operates under conditions of repression

First, by applying Couldry's (2004) media-as-practice paradigm, the study indicates that communication should be understood as a set of social practices rather than as technological processes. Second, by utilizing Lim's (2018) framework of roots, routes, and routers, it provides a structural model for analyzing how communication flows across hybrid and fragmented environments.

Most importantly, by applying Mouffe's (2007) theory of agonistic pluralism, this study reconceptualizes togetherness as a process of maintaining political identity through conflict rather than consensus. This allows collaborative media to be understood not only as communication tools but as political practices that sustain democratic engagement under repressive conditions.

Together, these frameworks contribute to a shift in MCS from a focus on digital mobilization toward an understanding of communication as infrastructural, relational, and oriented toward endurance.

These findings have broader implications for understanding protest communication beyond the Georgian context. They suggest that in environments where digital infrastructures are compromised, the sustainability of movements depends on the ability to develop alternative, human-centered communication practices. This has relevance for other contexts characterized by hybrid repression, where communication is not only about visibility but also about persistence over time.

This further underscores that collaborative media practices are not only reactive responses to repression but also proactive forms of meaning-making that enable protesters to continually reinterpret and renegotiate their political presence within shifting conditions.

8.4 Final reflection: Building and Protecting in the Cloud of Confusion

In the introduction to this thesis, I posed two questions that have served as the emotional and analytical heartbeat of this research: What can be built and what must be protected when the future feels uncertain? What does togetherness mean in times of turmoil?

Through the lens of the Georgian protest movement, the answer to these questions suggests that communication in repressive environments is not merely about the transmission of information, but a form of infrastructural and affective labor.

Building beyond digital fragility

What is being built in the streets of Tbilisi and the rural marketplaces of Georgia is an *infrastructure of endurance*. As digital platforms are increasingly subsumed by the state's *Cloud of Confusion* and strategic disinformation, the findings show that protesters have turned to creating *Human Routers*. These are not technical nodes but human bodies, mothers, students, and activists who physically carry *data packets* of resistance, trust, and vulnerability across a divided nation.

By building these alternative networks through intermodality linking prison letters to physical newspapers, protesters restore a sense of trust that digital media alone cannot provide. This labor is often invisible and exhausting, yet it is what allows the movement to survive *latency phases* when institutional channels are closed; the most durable thing that can be built is a human connection that refuses to be shadow-banned or erased.

Protecting political existence through conflict

What must be protected is the very possibility of a radical democratic identity. In a context where a state seeks to *demonize* and silence dissent, collaborative media

practices such as the *Black Dot* and the *1km Supra* serve as protective interventions. They mark a political frontier, drawing a line between a "we" that demands dignity and a “them” that offers only systemic dysfunction.

Drawing on Chantal Mouffe's theory of agonism, I reflect on the importance of *existing in conflict*. To protect one's political existence in Georgia is to refuse the state's demand for consensus or submission. It is the courage to remain an adversary rather than being transformed into an enemy to be destroyed. Symbols and rituals thus become the *memory actants* that protect the movement's history from being overwritten by a *sneaky occupation* (Young Protester 2).

Togetherness as a chain of Equivalence

Finally, this research suggests that collaborative media practices are central to the construction of what Mouffe (1992) conceptualizes as a chain of equivalence. Rather than emerging spontaneously, this chain is actively produced through communicative practices that link otherwise divided social actors into a shared political project.

In the Georgian context, collaborative media functions as the mechanism through which these connections are established. Symbolic, such as the *Black Dot*, enables recognition across differences by providing a shared visual reference point. Infrastructural practices, such as the *Voices of Freedom from Prison* newspaper, connect geographically and socially dispersed actors through human-mediated communication and trust-building. Embodied practices, such as the *1km Supra*, bring individuals together in shared physical space, allowing collective presence to be enacted despite political division.

Together, these interconnected practices, diverse experiences, such as the urban student facing police violence, the imprisoned activists writing from a cell, and the mother distributing newspapers in rural areas, are articulated as equivalent parts of a broader democratic struggle. Collaborative media thus does not simply represent protest; it actively constructs the relational links that enable a collective “we” to emerge.

Togetherness, in this sense, is not given but continuously produced through these practices. It is a fragile, often ambivalent, yet persistent effect of collaborative media,

which allows participants to remain connected within a shared political horizon despite ongoing conflict and uncertainty.

Future research could further explore how collaborative media practices evolve over longer time periods, particularly in relation to fatigue, burnout, and changing political conditions. Comparative studies across different national contexts would also help to determine the extent to which infrastructures of endurance are transferable beyond the Georgian case.

09 AI and Digital Tools Declaration

This thesis was supported by the use of digital tools during the writing and editing process. Microsoft Copilot was used to assist with structuring the text, refining clarity, and organizing and correcting the reference list. As English is not the author's first language (the author's native language is Swedish), Google Translate was used as a supportive tool to assist with translation and phrasing between Swedish and English. Additionally, Grammarly was used to correct spelling and grammar to ensure linguistic accuracy and readability. All interpretations, analytical arguments, and conclusions presented in this thesis are the original work of the author.

10 References

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